

137

# Mary Magdalene

*Set free by Jesus, faithful at the cross, and the first to see him risen.*

Mary Magdalene is named in all four Gospels. Jesus had cast seven devils out of her, and from then on she followed him, helping support his work from her own means. When most of the disciples fled, she stood near the cross. She watched where his body was laid, came early to the tomb, and became the first to see the risen Jesus and carry the news. She is often remembered as a repentant prostitute, but Scripture never says so; that is later tradition, from a sixth-century sermon. The Bible's Mary is a woman set free, loyal to the end.

## At a glance

|                        |                                                                     |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Name</i>            | Mary called Magdalene, probably meaning "of Magdala"                |
| <i>Home</i>            | Probably Magdala, a town on the western shore of the Sea of Galilee |
| <i>Healed</i>          | Jesus had cast seven devils out of her (Luke 8:2; Mark 16:9)        |
| <i>When</i>            | Followed Jesus c. AD 28–30, from Galilee to the cross               |
| <i>Key places</i>      | Galilee, Golgotha, the garden tomb                                  |
| <i>Key people</i>      | Jesus, Joanna, Susanna, Peter, John the apostle                     |
| <i>Main passages</i>   | Luke 8:1–3; Mark 15:40–16:11; John 19:25; 20:1–18                   |
| <i>Not the same as</i> | The sinful woman of Luke 7 or Mary of Bethany                       |

*"Jesus saith unto her, Mary. She turned herself, and saith unto him, Rabboni; which is to say, Master."*

John 20:16, KJV

# The life of Mary Magdalene

Dates are approximate (AD), with the crucifixion c. AD 30 (on the AD 33 view, add three years). The Gospels do not say when she was healed.

- c. AD 28–29

In Galilee

●

Set free

Jesus casts seven devils out of her. The Gospels never tell the story, only name it as what marked her life. *Luke 8:2; Mark 16:9*
- c. AD 29

Galilee

●

Travels with Jesus

With Joanna, Susanna and many others she goes with Jesus and the Twelve and "ministered unto him of their substance." *Luke 8:1–3*
- c. AD 30

Friday

●

At the cross

Having followed him up to Jerusalem, she stands by the cross with Jesus' mother and other women. *John 19:25; Mark 15:40–41*
- c. AD 30

Friday evening

●

Sees where he is laid

She and "the other Mary" watch the burial, then prepare spices and rest on the sabbath. *Matthew 27:61; Luke 23:55–56*
- c. AD 30

Sunday dawn

●

Finds the tomb open

While it is still dark she sees the stone taken away and runs to tell Peter and the disciple whom Jesus loved. *John 20:1–2*
- c. AD 30

Sunday

●

Meets the risen Lord

Weeping at the tomb, she takes Jesus for the gardener until he says her name. She goes and tells the disciples. *John 20:11–18*

## Group notes

## Key activities

*The Gospels name different groups of women at the cross and the tomb, but Mary Magdalene appears in every list, and usually first. Mark 16:9–20 is missing from some of the oldest manuscripts. The KJV includes it.*

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- 1 Received deliverance.** Jesus cast seven devils out of her. Scripture gives no details, only the fact of her freedom. *Luke 8:2*

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  - 2 Followed Jesus.** She joined the Twelve and other women on Jesus' preaching journeys through Galilee. *Luke 8:1–2*

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  - 3 Gave from her means.** With other women she supported Jesus and his disciples with her own money and goods. *Luke 8:3*

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  - 4 Stayed at the cross.** When the disciples had fled, she remained near Jesus as he died. *Mark 14:50; 15:40–41; John 19:25*

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  - 5 Watched the burial.** She saw where Jesus was laid, so she knew which tomb to come back to. *Mark 15:47*

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  - 6 Prepared spices.** She bought and prepared spices to anoint his body after the sabbath. *Luke 23:55–24:1; Mark 16:1*

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  - 7 Came to the tomb first.** She came while it was still dark and found the stone rolled away. *John 20:1*

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  - 8 Ran for help.** "They have taken away the Lord out of the sepulchre, and we know not where they have laid him." *John 20:2*

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  - 9 Stayed and wept.** After Peter and the other disciple went home, she stayed at the tomb, grieving. *John 20:10–13*

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  - 10 Knew his voice.** When Jesus called her "Mary," she turned and answered, "Rabboni." *John 20:14–16*

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  - 11 Carried the first message.** Jesus sent her to his brethren, and she went and told the disciples that she had seen the Lord. *John 20:17–18*

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  - 12 Was counted among the witnesses.** Luke names her first among the women who told these things to the apostles, though at first they did not believe. *Luke 24:10–11*

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# Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Mary Magdalene.

## Old Testament

|                                    |                                                            |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Echo: Song of Solomon 3:1-4</b> | Seeking "him whom my soul loveth," often read with John 20 |
| <b>Echo: Psalm 30:5</b>            | Weeping for a night, joy in the morning                    |
| <b>Echo: Isaiah 43:1</b>           | "I have called thee by thy name"                           |

## New Testament

|                                                  |                                                                                           |
|--------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Luke 8:1-3</b>                                | She travels with Jesus and supports his work                                              |
| <b>Matthew 27:55-28:10;<br/>Mark 15:40-16:11</b> | At the cross, the burial and the empty tomb                                               |
| <b>Luke 24:1-11</b>                              | Among the women who tell the apostles                                                     |
| <b>John 19:25; 20:1-18</b>                       | Her meeting with the risen Jesus                                                          |
| <b>Tradition</b>                                 | Gregory the Great (AD 591) merged her with Luke 7 and Mary of Bethany; Scripture does not |

### For discussion

- Observe:* What did Mary do in John 20:1-2, and again in John 20:11?
- Understand:* Why do you think Jesus appeared first to Mary and sent her to tell the others?
- Apply:* Mary gave from her own means. What time, money or skill could you give to God's work this month?
- Apply:* Mary knew Jesus when he spoke her name. Where do you need to hear that God knows you by name?